power.” Communists were no doubt taking advantage of the situation, but, he believed, at its root this was about nationalism. He understood American motivations—anti-communism and the desire not to abandon ally France—but he thought its approach was counterproductive, creating the opportunity for communists in Indochina.[49]

The differences were evident in spring 1954 as a settlement conference was being discussed. Dulles gave what came to be called his massive retaliation speech, and also made clear American reluctance to participate in a conference. Furthermore, he publicly dismissed criticism of the US nonrecognition of the Chinese communist regime. Dulles insisted this policy was “soberly rational” given Beijing’s “consistently and viciously hostile” behavior toward the US. He argued that communist promises were unreliable and outlined the administration’s preferred alternative of united action against the Chinese threat.[50]

Nehru found it “rather odd” and unhelpful that, ahead of the conference planned in Geneva, Dulles had given a speech emphasizing the need for collective action against the communist threat in East Asia.[51] He worried that the secretary of state would play spoiler at the talks so that a collective security organization would come into being as an alternative. The US, he felt, only seemed to be able to “think in terms of war or threat of war and massive retaliation,” which rendered a solution impossible.[52]

But Dulles’s move was deliberate—he thought it would serve as a warning to China. Given the imminent fall of Dien Bien Phu, it could also help the weak French negotiating position at the conference. Eisenhower had been skeptical of the British and French belief in the value of negotiations with the communists—and disapproved of the influence India seemed to have with British policymakers on this question. Nonetheless, the president did not want to break with allies who hoped to reach a settlement at Geneva. So he agreed to send US representatives to the conference, even as Dulles hoped that the negotiations would “acrimoniously collapse.”[53]

India’s fallen stock as an honest broker shaped the American attitude toward its involvement in the Geneva conference that April. Dulles’s initial reluctance about such a summit was indeed partly due to any related elevation of India to a leading role in Asia.[54] The US eventually succeeded in officially excluding India from the conference. Nonetheless, as the Indian